When Ambition Meets Discipline:

Explaining Elite Loyalty in Taiwan's Recall Election

Yi-Hung Chen
陳羿宏

National Taiwan University
Department of Political Science

r10322021@ntu.edu.tw

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Introduction

The Central Tension: Discipline vs. Ambition

The Fundamental Conflict

Political parties face a classic **Principal-Agent Problem**:

- **The Party (Principal):** Requires **collective discipline** to survive and mobilize.
- **The Politician (Agent):** Driven by **individual ambition** (career advancement).

The "Golden Opportunity" for Betrayal

When a colleague faces a recall, ambitious local elites have a strong incentive to **shirk** (save resources) or even **betray** (take over the seat).

The Context: 2025 Great Recall

- **Divided Government:** High tension between Executive and Legislature (Divided Government).
- **Puzzle** Despite the Golden Opportunity for betrayal, the outcome was shocking:
- **Outcome:** **Zero** successful recalls, defying expert predictions.

Research Question:
Why do ambitious agents remain loyal to the principal even when "betrayal" offers a clear path to promotion?

Literature Review

The Theoretical Foundation: Principal vs. Agent

The Principal: Party Discipline

- **The "Legislative Leviathan":** Parties control the agenda and enforce cohesion to solve collective action problems (Cox & McCubbins, 1993; Aldrich, 1995).
- **Goal:** Collective survival & Mobilization.

The Agent: Political Ambition

- **Progressive Ambition:** Politicians are rational actors driven by re-election and higher office (Schlesinger, 1966).
- **Goal:** Individual career advancement.

The Principal-Agent Tension:

- The agent's ambition often clashes with the principal's collective goal (e.g., costly mobilization)
- Should the agent act as a *Partisan* (loyal to party) or a *Trustee* (loyal to self/voters)?

The Empirical Gap: Local Mobilization

Existing Studies: The Black Box of Mobilization

- Literature confirms that local councilors rely on **personalistic networks** and **factions** for mobilization (Lee, 2022; Tang & Chen, 2013; Tsai et al., 2007).
- **Limitation:** These are predominantly qualitative or single-case studies.
- *Question: Is this bottom-up influence systematic at the national level?*

- **Traditional View:** Top-down coattails (President helps MPs)(Campbell, 1991; Huang & Wang, 2014)
- **Reverse Coattails (Bottom-Up):**
  - Local elites (mayors/councilors) mobilize "blocks of votes" for national candidates in exchange for pork/resources (Ames, 1994; Ventura, 2021).
  - This is an **active exchange mechanism**, not passive spillover.

My Argument: The 2025 Recall is a test of this exchange. If the exchange works, ambition should be neutralized.

Theoretical Framework

Model Derivation: The Strategic Interaction

Stage 1: The Agent's Maximization (Councilor)
The councilor maximizes utility, weighing party rewards (β) against effort costs (k) and personal ambition (ϕ):

$$\max_e U_c = \underbrace{\alpha + \beta e}_{\text{Party Reward}} - \underbrace{\frac{1}{2} k e^2}_{\text{Mobilization Cost}} - \underbrace{\phi e}_{\text{Opportunity Cost (Ambition)}}$$

Taking the First Order Condition (FOC) w.r.t. e:

$$\frac{\partial U_c}{\partial e} = \beta - ke - \phi = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad e = \frac{\beta - \phi}{k} \quad \text{(Reaction Function)}$$

Stage 2: The Principal's Optimization (Party)
The party anticipates the agent's reaction and designs the optimal incentive β^* to maximize its own utility U_p:

$$\max_\beta \Pi = \ldots \quad \Rightarrow \quad \text{Solving for optimal } \beta \text{ yields:} \quad \beta^* = 1 + \phi$$

Stage 3: Equilibrium Effort
Substituting the optimal contract β^* back into the agent's reaction function:

$$e^* = \frac{(1 + \phi) - \phi}{k} = \frac{1}{k}$$

Conclusion: The party perfectly neutralizes the ambition (ϕ).

Game-Theoretic Model: Rational Loyalty

The Agent's Calculation

An agent maximizes utility based on:

- β: Party rewards (Loyalty).
- ϕ: Personal Ambition (Temptation to shirk).
- k: Cost of mobilization.

Equilibrium Prediction

The party sets an optimal contract $\beta^* = 1 + \phi$ to neutralize ambition. Resulting Effort:

$$e^* = \frac{1}{k}$$

Hypothesis:

Even highly ambitious agents ("Star Councilors") will exert high effort if the party's incentive structure is credible.

Research Design

Case Selection & Methodology

Why the 2025 Recall?

- **Quasi-Experiment:** No presidential election = No top-down coattails.
- **Clean Identification:** Isolates the local mobilization effect.

Method: Propensity Score Matching (PSM)

Units of Analysis Villages

Treatment (T_i) **Star Councilor Presence**
(KMT councilors with vote shares > 2 SD above mean).
Proxy for High Ambition (ϕ) & Low Cost (k).

Outcome (Y_i) **Mobilization Rate**
(Anti-recall votes / Eligible voters).

Convaraites political confounders(DPP and KMT vote share in 2024), demographic, social structure (population density, dependency ratio, average age, and sex ratio), and socioeconomic (education attainment and household income)

Diagnostics: Covariate Balance

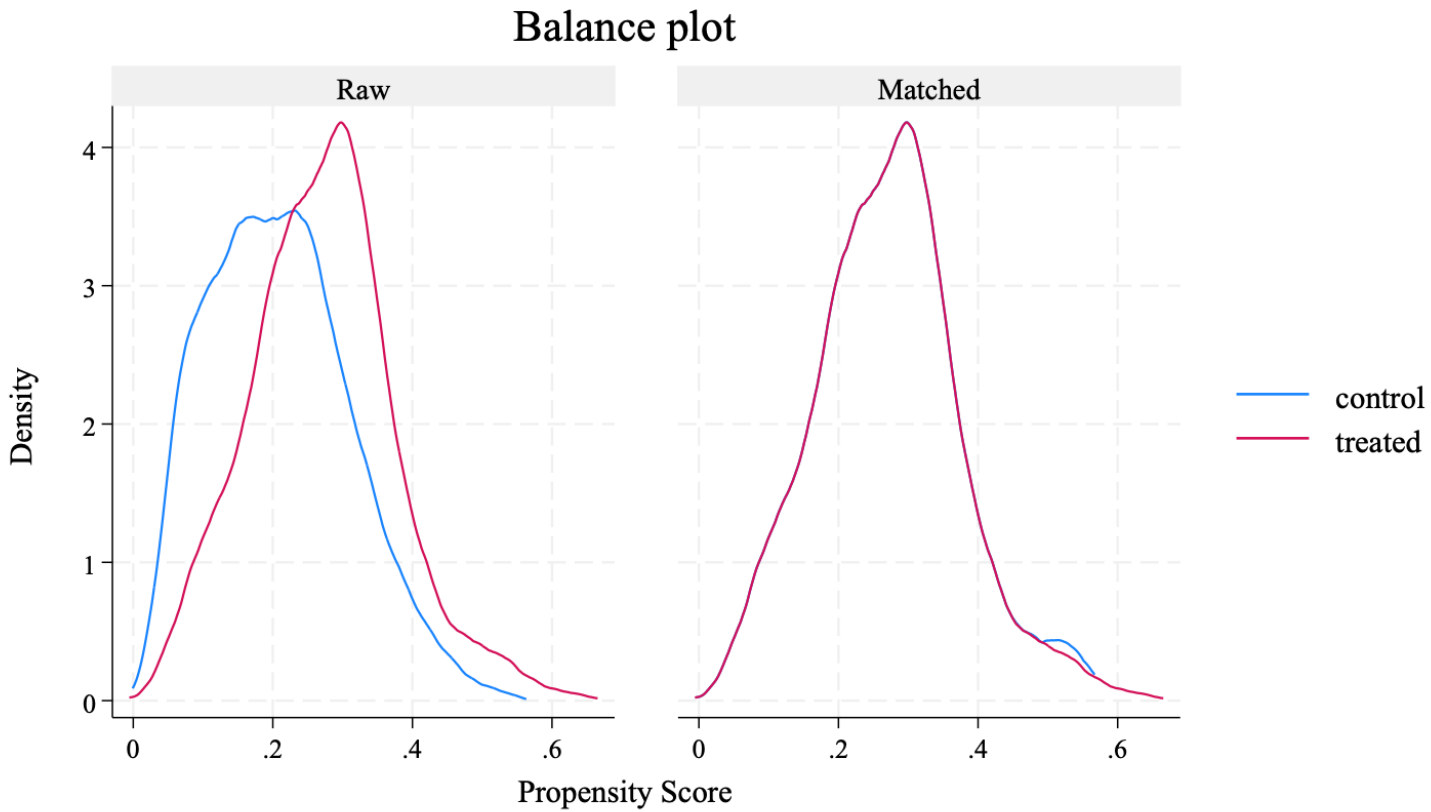


Figure: Balance Plot

Diagnostics: Covariate Balance

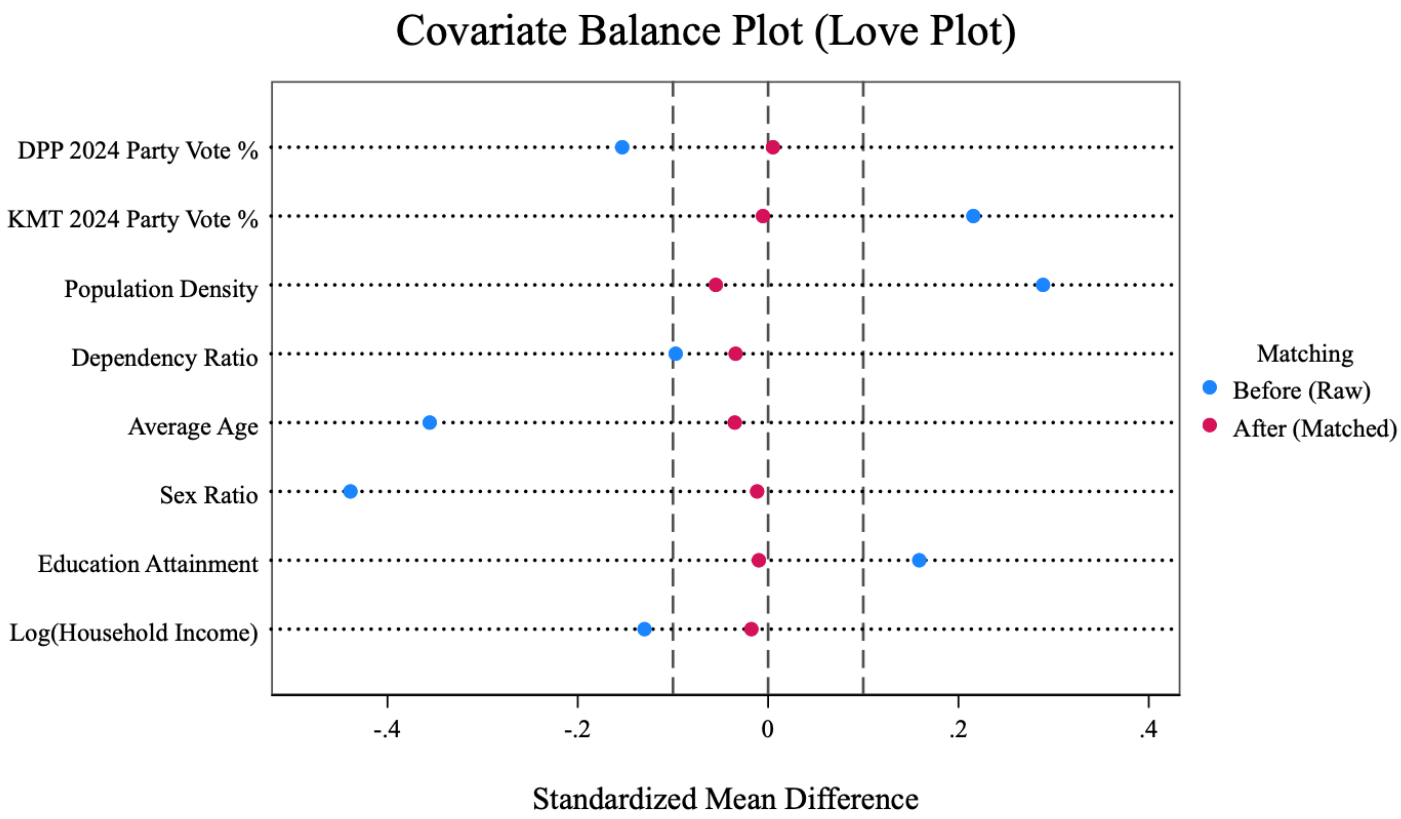
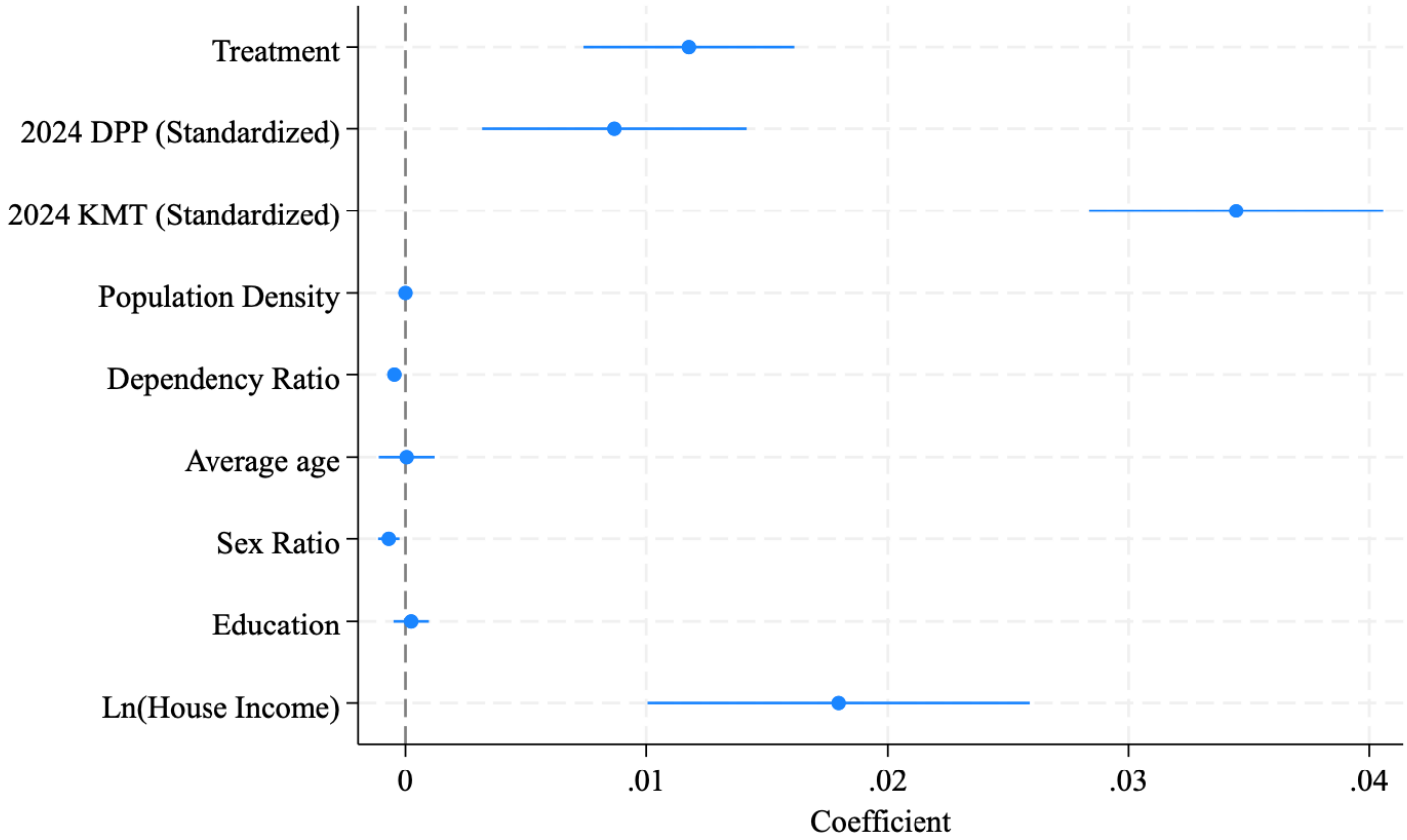


Figure: Love Plot: Covariates Diagnostics

Empirical Findings

Findings: The Reverse Coattail Effect



- **ATET = +1.15 percentage points**.
- This confirms that highly ambitious agents (Star Councilors) effectively mobilized support for the party.

Robustness Checks

The results remain robust across different model specifications.

Model	Matching Method	Effect Size	Sig.
Model 1	Nearest Neighbor (1:1)	+1.15%	***
Model 2	Regression Adjusted	+1.18%	***
Model 3	Lower Threshold (1 SD)	+1.18%	***
Model 4	Regression Adjusted (1 SD)	+1.13%	***
Model 5	Nearest Neighbor (1:3)	+1.03%	***
Model 6	Regression Adjusted (1:3)	+1.05%	***
Model 5	7/26 Recall	+0.99%	***
Model 6	8/23 Recall	+1.12%	*

Note: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Conclusion & Limitations

Conclusion

1. **Rational Loyalty:** Loyalty is an equilibrium strategy. The party successfully neutralized individual ambition (ϕ) through optimal incentives (β).
2. **Ambition Harnessed:** Star Councilors (most ambitious agents) became the most effective mobilizers.
3. **Reverse Coattail Verified:** Even in SNTV systems, local elites provide crucial support for national causes.

Research Limitations

Limitations

1. **Methodological Limitation (PSM):** PSM only controls for observable confounders. Unobserved variables, such as the **deep-rooted strength of local factions**, could still bias the estimates.
2. **Measurement of Ambition:** Using "Star Councilor" (past vote share) as a proxy for political ambition is a theoretical leap. Future research needs more direct measures.
3. **External Validity:** This study relies on a unique, low-salience recall context. It remains an open question whether this loyalty equilibrium holds in **general elections** with strong presidential coattails.

Thank you!

Q & A

r10322021@ntu.edu.tw